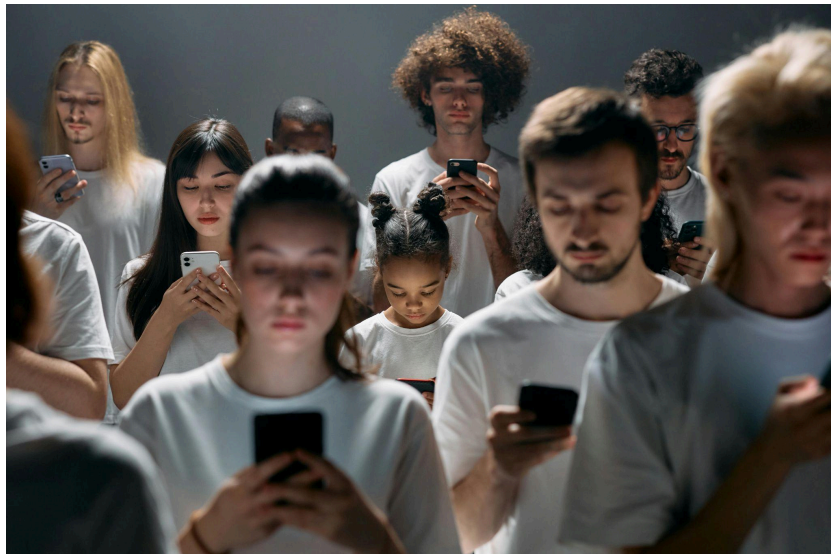


LYING THROUGH THEIR TEETH

How misinformation has overtaken civic responsibility

With the rise of social media and artificial intelligence, information has become more widely available than ever before. While this is beneficial in its own right, an excess of information and direct access to an audience have created possibilities for deception and fraud. Initially started with innocent pranks and jokes, misinformation has become a rampant problem in every facet of life. Considering the level of technology now available, a simple, illogical claim backed by no real evidence can be easily misrepresented as factual and accurate. Fabricated evidence, such as pictures and videos, can be created within minutes to convey a baseless point, ultimately creating confusion and mistrust between the general public and those in positions of authority. For Canadians in particular, social media and the news have become a point of contention as the internet becomes flooded with contrasting information. Now more than ever, it has become increasingly difficult to verify who is in the right and who is deliberately spreading misinformation.



(Pexels - cottonbro studio)

These days, misinformation is disguised in many forms, thus becoming extremely difficult to recognize and combat. Unlike in the past, where misinformation was confined to political propaganda and manufactured rumours, nowadays it can be found across multiple platforms with high accessibility ([Museum of Australian Democracy](#)). Below are some of the most common types of misinformation Canadians come across regularly.

Types of Misinformation:

- Misleading Headlines or Statistics:

Full news articles or research studies are very rarely read. As such, headlines and statistics are often overly exaggerated to “clickbait” the audience. This is often referred to as “Yellow Journalism,” where facts are hidden, and titles are sensationalized.

Example: A post on X featuring an article with the headline “100% increase” in inflation without providing evidence.

- AI-generated Content:

Now with the rise of artificial intelligence, realistic images, videos and audio can be created to depict real-life events. Often, they are manipulated to serve as proof for a certain claim.

Example: An AI video of the Prime Minister of Canada making a claim about a topic that fosters extremist values about a minority group.

- Conspiracy Theories:

While conspiracy theories have long existed, they have now become common with the internet. These consist of claims presented without tangible evidence, often perpetuating fear and distrust in the government.

Example: A YouTube video suggesting that certain government officials are involved in global events without providing proof.

- Out-of-context Clips:

This is one of the most common forms of misinformation, where old and out-of-context videos are used to make misleading claims. They are often cherry-picked moments without proper background context, and are attributed to irrelevant pieces of information.

Example: A clip of a politician giving a speech, taken out of context, can create mistrust and confusion.

- Resurfacing Old Content:

Old news stories and events are often resurfaced incorrectly to suggest that they are current. They are intended to provide “context” to current events by disguising something old as new.

Example: A clip of a natural disaster from 2015 recirculating to mislead viewers into thinking it is happening now.

Fact-Checking Examples

As it has been proven, misinformation is extremely common on social media. Therefore, below are a few real-life examples taken from the platform X, where users made inaccurate claims disguised with fabricated evidence.

1. Alberta Separatism Movement and "Joining the US"



Platform:

X (Twitter)

Claim:

The main objective of Alberta's separatist movement is to join the United States as the 51st state.

Why is it misleading?

This post is misleading because it generalizes one individual's claim to represent the objective of the entire group. It also references an old Facebook video, making the issue seem current and more supported than it is.

Fact-Checked Explanation:

A majority of separatist movements in Alberta solely focus on independence from Canada, not U.S. statehood. In fact, one of the main advocacy groups, Alberta Property Project, emphasizes its desire for independence, with no objective highlighted in its push for becoming a U.S. state. Jeffrey Rath, the man quoted in the video, has also made this publicly clear, stating, [“The only thing we’re interested in is a free and independent Alberta, not statehood.”](#)

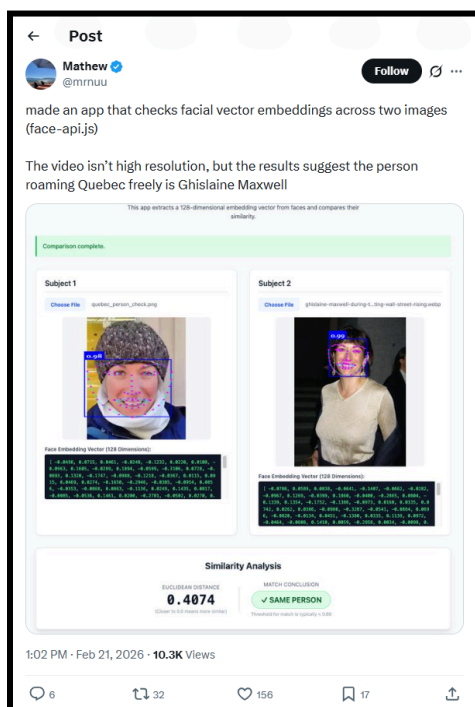
Sources:

<https://www.reuters.com/world/alberta-separatists-step-up-efforts-leave-canada-after-meeting-with-trump-2026-02-12/>

<https://albertaprospertyproject.com/about-us/>

<https://www.ctvnews.ca/canada/article/alberta-separatists-step-up-efforts-to-leave-canada-after-meeting-with-trump-officials/>

2. [Ghislaine Maxwell in Quebec](#)

**Platform:**

X (Twitter)

Claim:

A woman seen in Quebec, Canada, resembles Ghislaine Maxwell, suggesting that she is freely living in Canada despite being imprisoned. The tweet confirms her identity using an AI database to suggest that the woman spotted in Quebec is, in fact, Maxwell.

Why is it misleading?

This post is misleading because it relies on an AI facial recognition platform alongside a low-quality video to suggest identity without verified evidence. It also ignores legal records showing Maxwell's imprisonment.

Fact-Checked Explanation:

The facts clearly debunk this theory. Maxwell has been in prison since 2022 for a 20-year sentence and is currently held at a federal prison in Texas. Her imprisonment is confirmed by the U.S. Bureau of Prisons, and there is no evidence of release. An investigation into the viral video by CBC News also confirmed the video to be misleading, with experts suggesting the video has been visually manipulated to make the woman appear to resemble Maxwell.

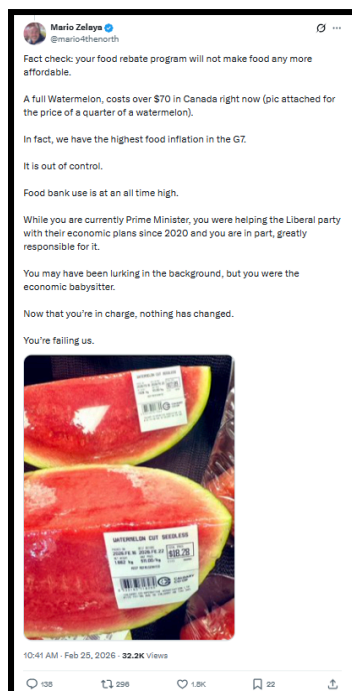
Sources:

<https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/czd049y2qymo>

<https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cvgv5yre39zo>

<https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/montreal/ai-video-quebec-city-maxwell-9.7104284>

3. Watermelon Costs in Canada



Platform:

X (Twitter)

Claim:

The reply to Prime Minister Mark Carney's post implies that a full watermelon costs over \$70 in Canada.

Why is it misleading?

The post is misleading because it makes this claim based on the price of pre-cut watermelon, which is significantly more expensive due to the added labour costs, packaging and convenience. It uses this price to generalize the cost of a whole watermelon.

Fact-Checked Explanation:

Even during off-season months, a whole watermelon in Canada typically costs around \$7-\$12. The image used in the post is a pre-cut watermelon, which is generally more expensive than the whole fruit. While food inflation exists in Canada, it does not support extreme claims like a \$70 watermelon. Local supermarkets in the GTA, at the time of the tweet, were reported to be selling whole watermelons for as low as \$10.

Sources:

https://www.nofrills.ca/en/red-seedless-watermelon/p/20067326001_EA

https://iqbalfoods.ca/product/watermelon-large-each-360637?srsId=AfmBOopEfzMv8CSqIEhj_y1PoIHunbzPe6RSRmhuxI3oAD3p_ugquORALyI

<https://www.thetakeout.com/1995424/why-pre-cut-produce-overpriced/>

<https://www.bluebookservices.com/canadas-food-price-report-2026-predicts-canadian-will-spend-more-on-food/>

Misinformation Examples



Real Scenarios taken from X (Twitter)

1. Alberta Separatism & “Joining the U.S.”



Claim

Alberta wants to become the 51st U.S. state.



Fact

Most movements focus on independence from Canada. There is no official push for statehood.

2. Ghislaine Maxwell “Spotted” in Quebec



Claim

Ghislaine Maxwell is secretly living in Canada.



Fact

She has been imprisoned in the U.S. since 2022. The video is misleading and artificially generated.

3. Watermelon Prices in Canada



Claim

A watermelon costs over \$70 in Canada.



Fact

Whole watermelons typically cost around \$10. The claim is based on overpriced pre-cut fruit.

Verification Tools and Methods

Now, while misinformation is on the rise, there are a plethora of tools and tricks available to help stay safe from its dangers. However, a [2025 survey by the Canadian Journalism Foundation \(CJF\)](#) found that 88 percent of Canadians are concerned about AI-generated deception in the news, with 47 percent encountering misinformation daily. Therefore, to stay safe from online misinformation, it is important to be equipped with the right tools.

The rule of thumb when doomscrolling or actively pursuing the news is to question the claims and the source before relying on them for accuracy. Use your own judgment and never take anything for granted. If something seems illogical or too good to be true, it is most likely misinformation. But if something creates doubt, do a quick Google search to verify the accuracy of the claim. External research from reputable sources should either confirm or debunk the claim, helping you find the correct information. For all the examples shown above, this was the most efficient verification method.

However, there are also online resources that can make this process quick and simple. Below are some tools to keep in mind.

1. [Reverse Image Search](#)

Use to check if images have been reused or taken out of context.

2. [Google Toolbox](#)

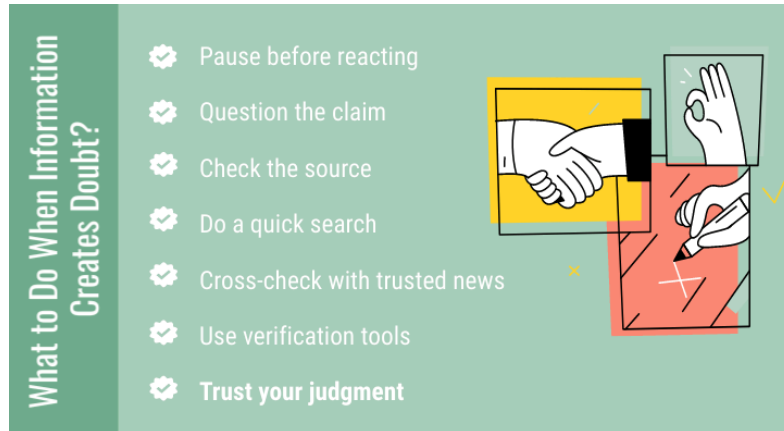
Showcases some of the most recent examples of misinformation popular on the internet.

3. [Government Sources](#)

To confirm new policies or statistics, go directly to the official government source.

4. [Information Laundromat](#)

Explore how content is copied and spread across the internet, finding similarities in claims and site structures.



Therefore, digital literacy is crucial for Canadians in this day and age. When most of the information we consume comes directly from the internet, it is important to know how to differentiate right from wrong. If this awareness is not ingrained in our residents, then distrust and uncertainty will ensue between the government and its citizens. As we have witnessed, misinformation is not only limited to global issues but is also present in everyday, trivial matters. If a course of action is not taken to identify the information circulating online, it will continue to shape public opinion in misleading and harmful ways.